—it had embraced a knockoff version, convenient for its own purposes. The verification theory of meaning couldn't actually justify most formulations of the Copenhagen interpretation. And few physicists truly believed, as the Vienna Circle did, that electrons didn't exist. Physicists had simply adopted a caricature of the positivist attitude. If something can't be seen, why worry about it? Things that can't be seen are meaningless anyhow. And if anyone still wasn't convinced, there was a large pile of borrowed and bastardized arguments from the positivists about why this kind of reasoning worked, enough to keep most people from worrying—especially with the wide variety of interesting work to be done using the mathematical machinery of quantum physics.

This cartoonish parody of positivism, despite its flaws, worked well for the practical-minded physics that was encouraged during and after World War II. And some of the Vienna Circle's members, like Schlick and Frank, did argue that the Copenhagen interpretation had a solid philosophical grounding in accepted tenets of logical positivism. But, just as the war brightened the prospects for the Copenhagen interpretation, it dimmed the fortunes of the positivists themselves.

The Vienna Circle started running into serious trouble in the mid-1930s, as fascism crept over Europe. The deteriorating political situation convinced some of the leaders of the circle and their allies that it was time to leave Europe altogether. Reichenbach was forced out of his job in Berlin when Hitler came to power in 1933 and fled to the University of Istanbul for several years. Fascists seized power in Austria at roughly the same time, and by 1934 Czechoslovakia was in a precarious position as the only functioning democracy anywhere in Eastern Europe. Carnap, who had moved to the University of Prague several years earlier, saw the writing on the wall. With the help of the American positivist philosopher Charles Morris, Carnap moved to the United States in 1935 and took a job at the University of Chicago shortly thereafter. Schlick stayed on in Vienna but faced increasing political problems: both the fascist government and the Austrian Nazi Party saw him (rightly) as a political and ideological